



Prof. Dr.-Ing. Lamyia Abdullah [Lamyia.Abdullah@provadis-hochschule.de](mailto:Lamyia.Abdullah@provadis-hochschule.de)

## Interkulturelle Kommunikation und heterogene Teams Lecture Notes- 05: Leadership + Conflict Management

## We mentioned Leadreship... i.e.

### Leader Actions [stages of teams]

- Forming → **Structure & direction**
- Storming → **Conflict** management
- Norming → **Trust** building
- Performing → **Autonomy**
- Adjourning → **Reflection**

Teams **fail** when **leaders**  
**treat all stages the same**

### Key Takeaways for All Organization Cultural Models :

- **Leadership** is **Crucial**: Leaders must model and champion cultural sensitivity.
- **Proactive D&I**: Implement **Diversity & Inclusion** initiatives (**training, policies**).
- **Psychological Safety**: Create an **environment** where all feel safe to voice cultural needs.
- **Adaptation over Assimilation**: Promote mutual learning, not just fitting in.

### Cultural Sensitivity

#### 3. Inclusive **Leadership** & Team Norms:

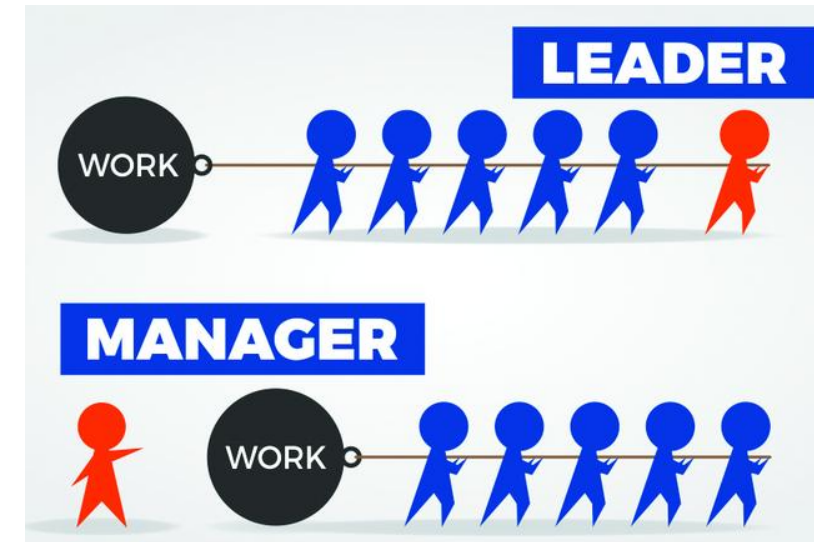
- **Focus**: Leaders and team actively shaping an inclusive environment where diversity is leveraged.
- **How**: Setting **clear expectations**, fostering **psychological safety**, celebrating diversity, **addressing biases**.





## Leadership in Intercultural Teams

## Leadership vs Management [general]



### Leadership

- Focus on **people**
- Creates **vision and direction**
- **Motivates** and **develops** others

### Management

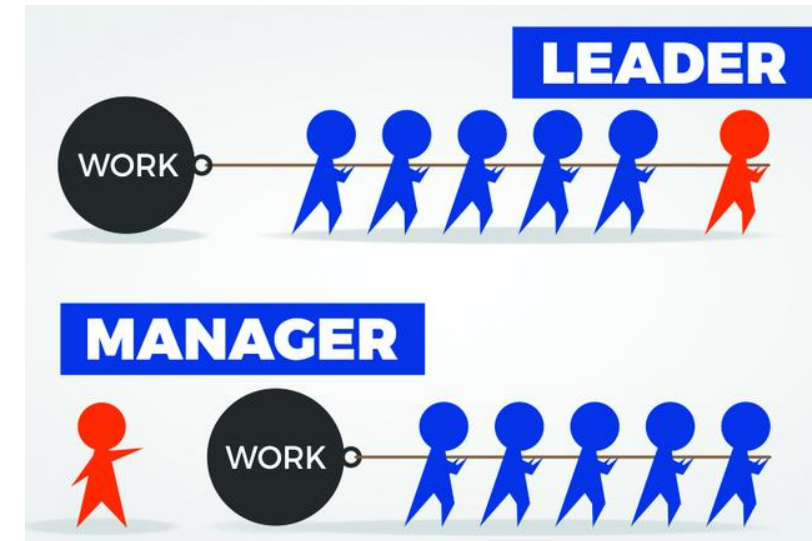
- Focus on **tasks and processes**
- Organises and controls work
- **Ensures** **execution**

Teams need **both**  
**Leaders** **adapt** behaviour depending on the situation

## Leadership vs Management [general], cont.



<https://www.susannemadsen.co.uk/blog/what-is-the-difference-between-management-and-leadership-and-how-does-it-relate-to-project-managers>

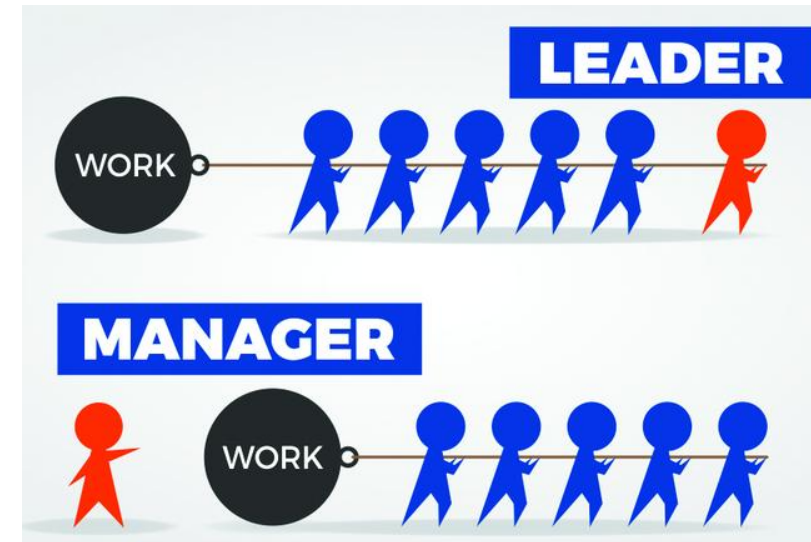


## Reflection ?

Management **organises** work  
Leadership **influences** people



In your Team :  
who is **leading** and who is **managing**?



## Key challenges (Previous content)

- Different **communication** styles (e.g. direct vs indirect)
- Different expectations of **hierarchy**
- Different **views** on **responsibility**
- Different approaches to **conflict**

Hofstede

Trompenaars

Cultural sensitivity block

→ Leadership becomes **harder** because: **behaviour** is **interpreted** differently across cultures!

→ Ability to **understand, adapt and work effectively across cultures.**

### **4 elements (simplified):**

- Awareness (recognise differences)
- Knowledge (understand cultures)
- Strategy (adjust thinking)
- Action (adapt behaviour)

**This is the practical application of:**  
cultural sensitivity  
cultural models

## Leadership Must **Adapt** to Culture

### Examples:

| Situation              | Leadership behaviour |
|------------------------|----------------------|
| High hierarchy culture | more direction       |
| Low hierarchy culture  | more participation   |
| Direct cultures        | clear feedback       |
| Indirect cultures      | softer communication |

There is **no** universal leadership style

→ **Good leaders:**

- adapt
- observe
- adjust

## Lateral Leadership - Leading Without Authority



Influence others **without formal power**

# Practical Leadership Tools

What **Effective** Leaders Do in Diverse Teams?

## Tools:

- Make **expectations clear**
- **Adapt** communication style
- Create **psychological safety**
- Clarify **roles** (e.g. GRPI)
- Address **misunderstandings early**



## Leadership Styles

### Studies

**Leadership Styles in Multicultural Groups:  
Americans and East Asians Working Together  
Aritz and Walker, 2014**

<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/2329488413516211>



## Research Focus

Investigated how **culture influences leadership behaviors** and the resulting effects on **participation, inclusion,** and **satisfaction** in multicultural teams, specifically between Americans and East Asians.

## Key Leadership Styles Identified

- **Directive Leadership**

- Characterized by minimal listening, abrupt topic shifts, and low elaboration.
- Typically dominates the discourse, with one-way instruction flow.

- **Cooperative Leadership**

- Involves moderate engagement from team members.
- Some listening occurs, though still predominantly leader-led in shaping discussion.

- **Collaborative Leadership**

- Encourages **active** participation, **extended** elaboration, and **mutual** idea development between leader and team members

### Outcomes & Insights

#### • Participation and Inclusion

- East Asian participants often reported **lower inclusion and satisfaction** when leadership was **directive**, partly due to **disparities in English language proficiency** and less opportunity to contribute.

#### • Importance of Communication Strategy

- Using “**redundant communication strategies**”—like **repeating** key information across channels or rephrasing—**helped improve understanding**, especially for team members with limited language proficiency.

#### • Media Richness & Inclusion

- **Richer** communication media (like video calls) enhanced **feelings of inclusion and satisfaction**, whereas leaner, text-centric media (e.g., email or forums) supported **task accomplishment** but may undermine relational aspects.

## Leadership Styles in Multicultural Groups, Aritz and Walker 2014 study, cont.

### Styles & Effects

| Leadership Style              | Characteristics                                                          | Effects on Multicultural Teams                                                  |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Directive</b>              | <b>Minimal</b> listening, <b>abrupt</b> shifts, <b>leader-controlled</b> | Less inclusion, dissatisfaction experienced by East Asian members               |
| <b>Cooperative</b>            | <b>Moderate</b> member input, some <b>listening</b>                      | Better participation than directive, though still uneven                        |
| <b>Collaborative</b>          | <b>Active</b> participation, <b>shared</b> elaboration                   | Highest inclusion and satisfaction—even in linguistically diverse groups        |
| <b>Communication Strategy</b> | <b>Redundant</b> messaging across <b>media</b>                           | Enhances understanding and inclusion, especially for lower-proficiency speakers |
| <b>Media Richness</b>         | <b>Rich</b> vs. lean communication                                       | Rich media → better relational outcomes;<br>Lean → focused on task completion   |

## Leadership Styles

### Studies

**Cultural Intelligence and Leadership Styles: Examining the Impact of Multicultural Teams on Organizational Productivity and Employee Satisfaction**

**Saini & Banerjee, 2024**

<https://doi.org/10.52783/eel.v14i3.1940>



## Research Focus:

Explores how **cultural intelligence (CQ)** and **leadership styles** interact to influence productivity and satisfaction in multicultural teams.

**Cultural Intelligence** is abbreviated as **CQ** by analogy with IQ (Intelligence Quotient) and EQ (Emotional Intelligence / Emotional Quotient).

The "Q" stands for **Quotient** (a standardized measure or capability).

CQ therefore signals a **measurable capability** related to how effectively a person can **function across cultures**.

So just like IQ = Cognitive ability and EQ = Emotional ability,  
CQ = Cultural capability/intelligence.

# Cultural Intelligence and Leadership Styles, Saini & Banerjee 2024 study

## Research Focus:

Explores how **cultural intelligence (CQ)** and **leadership styles** interact to influence productivity and satisfaction in multicultural teams.

## Key Leadership Style Identified

- **Transformational Leadership**: Emphasizes inspiring vision, individualized consideration, and enabling followers to transcend routine.

Combined with high **Cultural Intelligence (CQ)**, transformational leadership **becomes a powerful** for **enhancing** outcomes in **multicultural** settings.

## Main Findings

- Leaders with **high CQ** who use **transformational leadership** drive:
  - ☐ Improved **team collaboration**
  - ☐ Stronger **team cohesion**
  - ☐ Increased **organizational productivity**
- Multicultural teams led by such leaders report **higher job satisfaction**, thanks to:
  - ☐ **Inclusive** leadership **climates**
  - ☐ **Supportive** cross-cultural environments

### Additional aspects!

- **Mechanism**

Inclusive + **adaptive** leadership via **CQ** drives **positive** multicultural team **dynamics**

- **Implications**

Emphasizes CQ **training** and transformational **modelling** for leaders in global orgs

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, and several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed. The scene is set against a bright, clear sky.

**Case Exercise:  
Leadership in Intercultural Teams**

## Case Exercise: Leadership in Intercultural Teams



A team is working on a global virtual product launch.

Team members come from: Germany, Brazil, South Korea, and United States



### The Situation:

- A team leader pushes for **fast decisions and clear feedback**
- Some team members remain **silent in meetings**
- Others feel the communication is **too direct and aggressive**
- Deadlines are at **risk**

### Problem

The leader believes: “**The team is not performing**”

Task: Next Slide

## Case Exercise: Leadership in Intercultural Teams, cont.



### Group Discussion [10 min]

Analyse the situation using your leadership knowledge:

#### 1. Identify Leadership Mistakes

- What is the leader doing wrong?
- Which behaviours create problems?

#### 2. Analyse the Causes

Are the issues related to:

- Culture?
- Communication?
- Leadership style?

#### 3. Suggest Improvements

- What should the leader do differently?
- How can the team work more effectively?

Think practically:  
**What would YOU do as the leader?**

## Final Remarks!

The problem is **NOT** [completely] the team

The problem is:  
the leader's **inability** to adapt

**Reflection Question:**

"How would you adapt your leadership style in this team?"



**Any Questions ?**

Remember: You Have tools/understanding to :



- recognise leadership challenges
- apply cultural intelligence
- adapt behaviour
- [basics to] lead diverse teams effectively

## Related resource

### Talks

- **Riding the waves of culture: Fons Trompenaars**  
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hmyfjKjcbm0>

- **How Culture Drives Behaviours**  
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=l-Yy6poJ2zs>



**The Concept of Cultural Intelligence**  
<https://www.mindtools.com/aisl5uv/cultural-intelligence?from=search>

**Cultural Intelligence Tests and Survey - free**  
<https://georginabarquin.com/cultural-intelligence-free-tests/>



**The Cultural Intelligence Center (CQC)**  
<https://culturalq.com/>

## Conflicts Management Introduction

Have you ever experienced conflict in a team?"



"What comes to mind when you hear 'conflict in teams'?"



### Objectives

- Identify how cultural values influence conflict
- Recognize your own conflict style
- Apply strategies to manage intercultural conflict

**Move from:**

Diagnosing problems

→ to **managing and resolving** conflicts professionally

# What is Conflict?

**Conflict =**  
**a difference in goals, values, or perceptions**

Such as:

- real workplace conflicts
- hierarchy issues
- communication problems



Conflict is often: **not** personal but structural or cultural

# Why Does Conflict Happen in Diverse Teams?

- Miscommunication or Indirectness

## [Poor Communication]

- Cultural values and **Assumptions**
- Hierarchical vs. Equal-status expectations
- Face-saving vs. **Assertiveness**
- **Stress**



### Key causes:

- Cultural differences
- Communication misunderstandings
- Role ambiguity (GRPI link)
- Power differences
- Stress / deadlines

Conflict is often: **not** personal but structural or cultural

## Conflict Can Be Positive

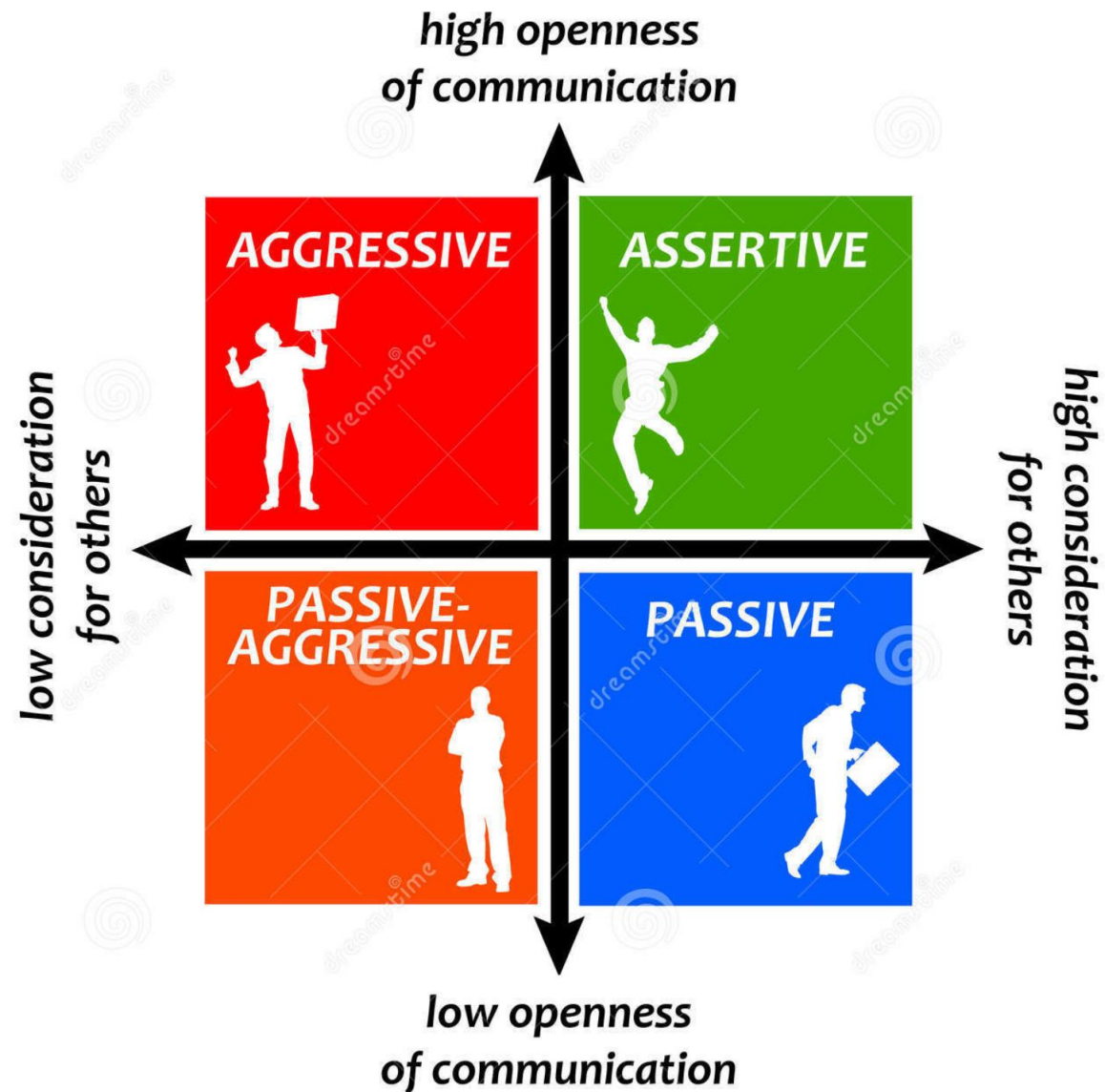
- Conflict is *natural and inevitable*
- Can **clarify misunderstandings**
- Can **increase creativity** and **innovation**

Conflict  $\neq$  Bad

## 5 Benefits of Healthy Conflict in the Workplace



<https://www.risely.me/5-benefits-of-healthy-conflict-at-work/>



## Types of Conflict:

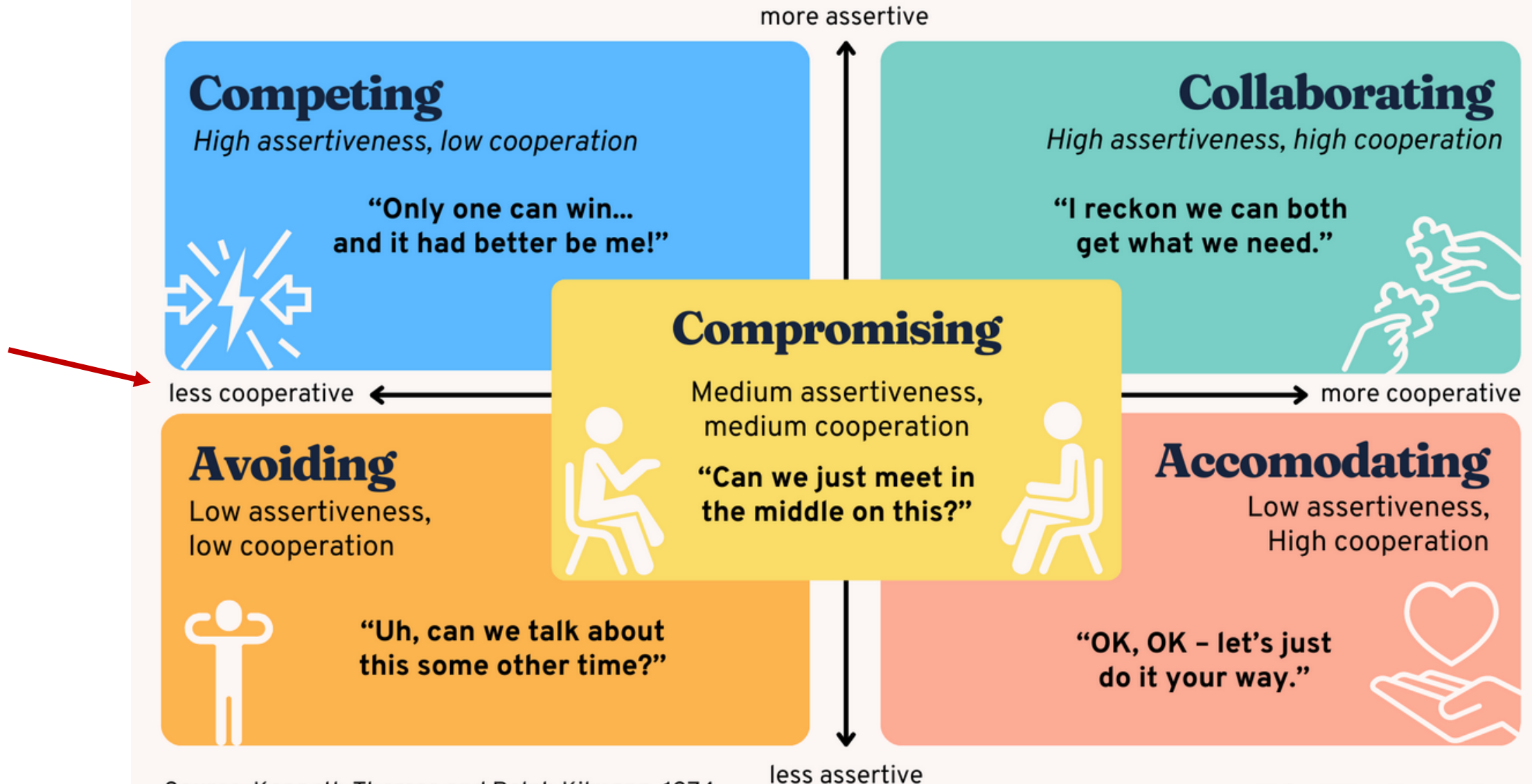
### Task vs Relationship Conflict

- Task conflict → **ideas**,
- work Relationship conflict → **personal**

Task conflict can **improve** performance  
Relationship conflict **damages** teams

## How People Deal with Conflict ?

# Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Model

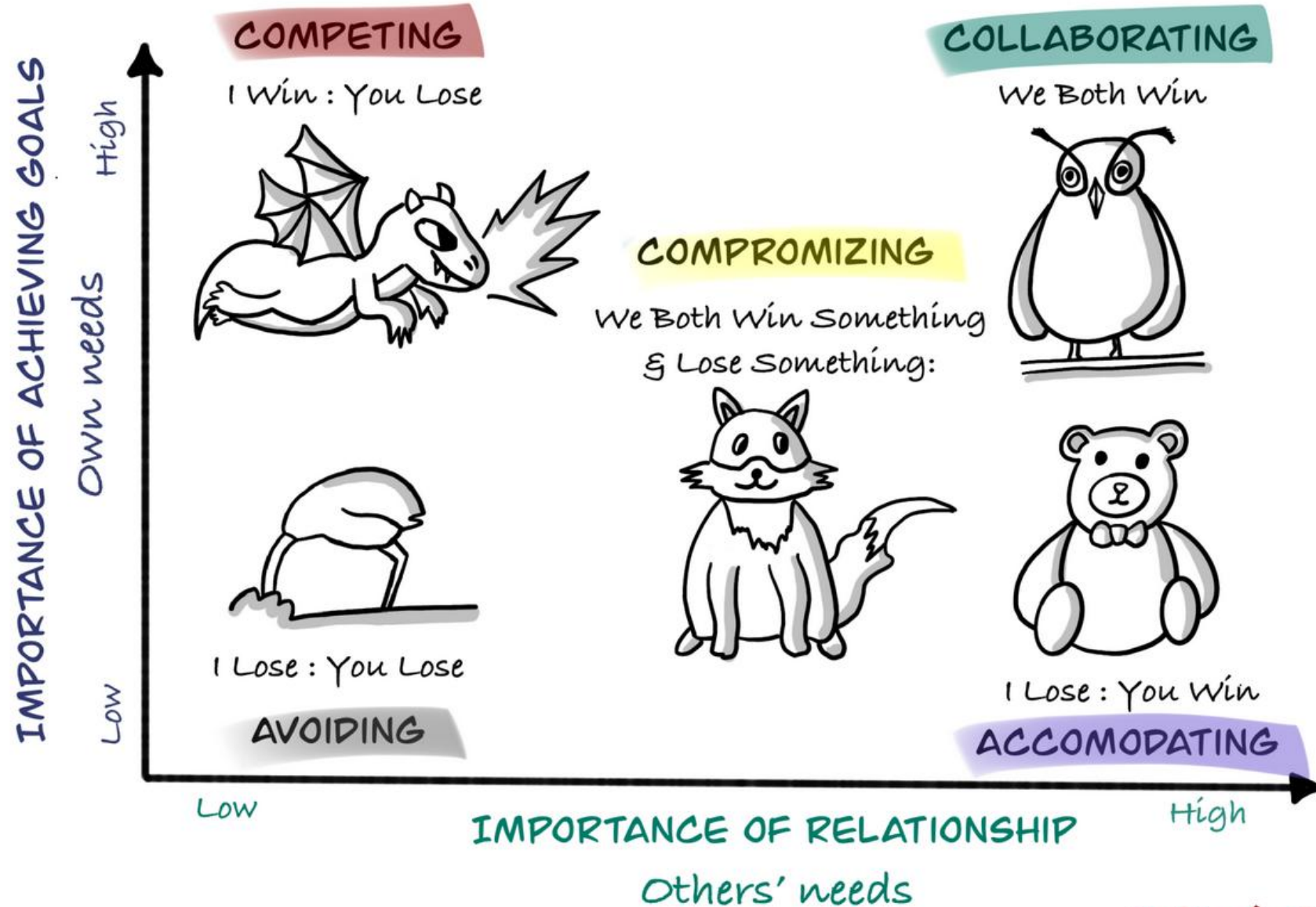


Source: Kenneth Thomas and Ralph Kilmann, 1974

Prof. Lamy Abdullah - IKHT - BINT24 - SoSe2026

**BiteSize** Learning

# THOMAS-KILMANN CONFLICT MANAGEMENT STYLES



JuliaVastrik.com

## Self- Assessment



### **Conflict Styles Assessment** [10 mins]

<https://jobcannon.io/tests/conflict-styles>



- **Individually [10 min]: discover** your conflict style.
- How might it be misinterpreted in a different cultures? [breakout rooms **10 mins**]
- Each group select one style to discuss and share [**10 mins** ]

### **Additional Assessments:**

- **Lincoln University Conflict Management Questionnaire**  
[https://www.lincoln.edu/\\_files/student-life/Conflict-Management-Styles-Quiz.pdf](https://www.lincoln.edu/_files/student-life/Conflict-Management-Styles-Quiz.pdf)
- **Conflict Management Styles Quiz, The North Carolina State University (NCSU)**  
<https://facultyombuds.ncsu.edu/files/2015/11/Conflict-management-styles-quiz.pdf>



## Don't Assume Intent

Avoid presuming the impact of your words

## Ask Clarifying Questions

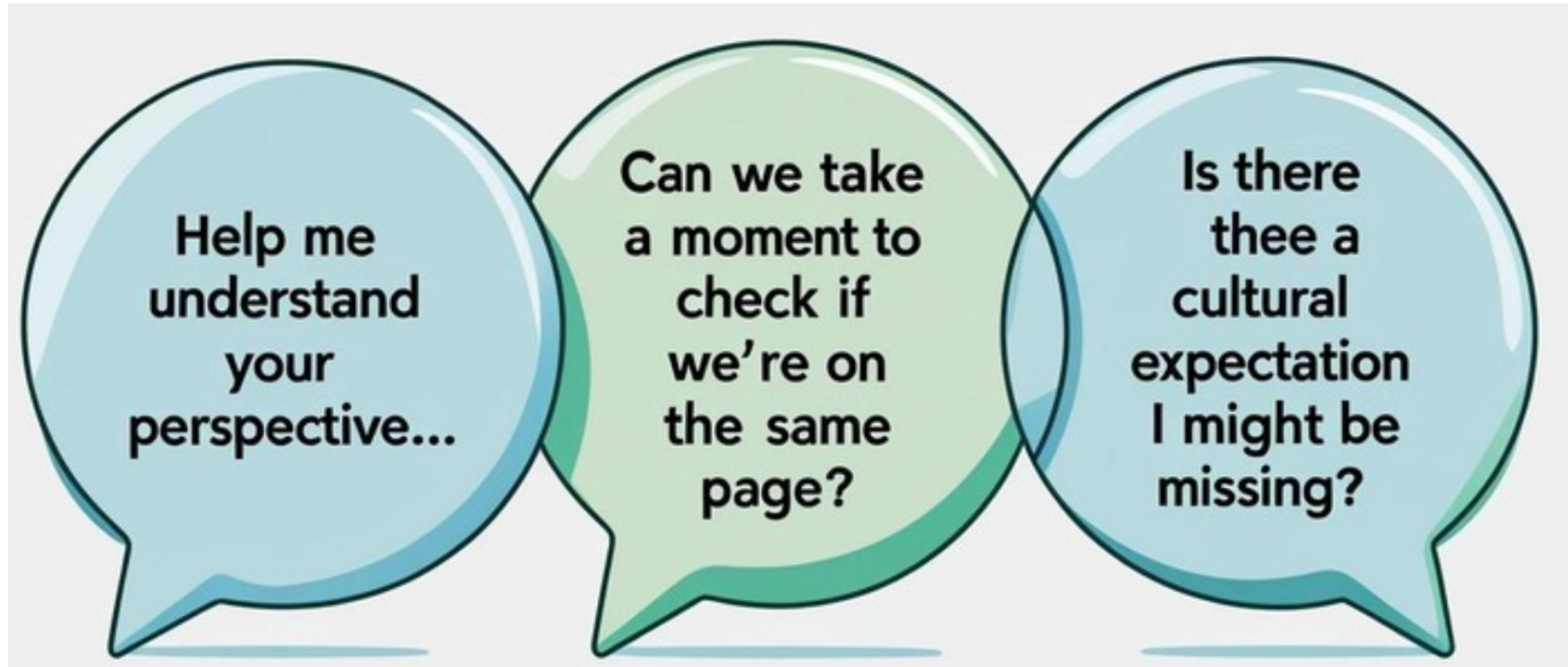
Seek understanding through open-ended inquiries

## Respect Face-Saving Strategies

Maintain dignity and respect in interactions

## Use Culturally Sensitive Language

Employ language that respects cultural nuances



Which phrase feels **most** natural to you?

**Least?**

## Reflection & Takeaways



- My default **conflict style** is...
- In a diverse team, I need to remember...
- **One strategy** I will try is...



Exercises and assessments are recommended to be revisited  
frequently throughout the career development life-time 😊

**They are not only for one time experience!**

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a diverse group of graduates in black gowns, cheering and throwing their caps into the air. The scene is filled with joy and accomplishment, with several caps captured mid-air against a bright, overcast sky.

## **Conflict Management in Diverse Teams**

### **Put things together**

# Conflict Management in Diverse Teams



**Effective Conflict Management in Multicultural Teams =**

**CQ + Inclusive Leadership + Collaborative Processes**

## **Practical steps:**

- Clarify facts,
- Understand perspectives
- Identify root cause (GRPI again)
- Agree on solution
- Follow up

## Evidence-based tips

### 1. Recognize Cultural Conflict Triggers

- ☐ Different **communication norms** (direct vs. indirect)
- ☐ **Power distance** expectations (hierarchical vs. egalitarian)
- ☐ Varied **attitudes toward conflict** (avoidance vs. confrontation)

**Tip: Train leaders to decode cultural signals before escalating issues.**



### Evidence-based tips

#### 2. Use Collaborative Problem-Solving

- ❑ Apply **collaborative leadership** → encourage shared discussion and idea elaboration (Aritz & Walker, 2014).
- ❑ Avoid overly **directive styles** in diverse teams, which reduce inclusion.

**Tip: Facilitate structured turn-taking so all voices are heard.**



### Evidence-based tips

#### 3. Build Psychological Safety

- ❑ Create a **climate** where mistakes, dissent, and diverse views are **safe to express**.
- ❑ **Inclusive leadership behaviours** (**listening**, valuing uniqueness) are strongly linked to **lower turnover** ( $\rho = -.52$ ) and **higher creativity** ( $\rho \approx .44$ ).

**Tip: Leaders should explicitly invite input from quieter cultural groups.**



### Evidence-based tips

#### 4. Adapt Conflict Styles with CQ

Leaders with high **Cultural Intelligence (CQ)** can **flex** between:

- ☐ **Integrating** (collaborative, win-win)
- ☐ **Compromising** (balanced)
- ☐ **Accommodating** (relationship-preserving, useful in high-context cultures)

**Tip:** Teach leaders to **diagnose when to adapt vs. when to push for direct resolution.**



### Evidence-based tips

#### 5. Leverage Mediation & Neutral Spaces

- ❑ Use **third-party facilitators** when conflicts are culturally **charged**.
- ❑ **Neutral ground rules** (e.g., structured agendas, shared decision-making) **prevent dominance by one cultural style**.

**Tip:** Rotate **facilitators** across cultural subgroups.



### Evidence-based tips

#### 6. Focus on Common Goals

- ❑ Frame discussions around **shared outcomes** (project success, innovation).
- ❑ Research shows diversity's positive effect on performance is strongest in **complex tasks**—

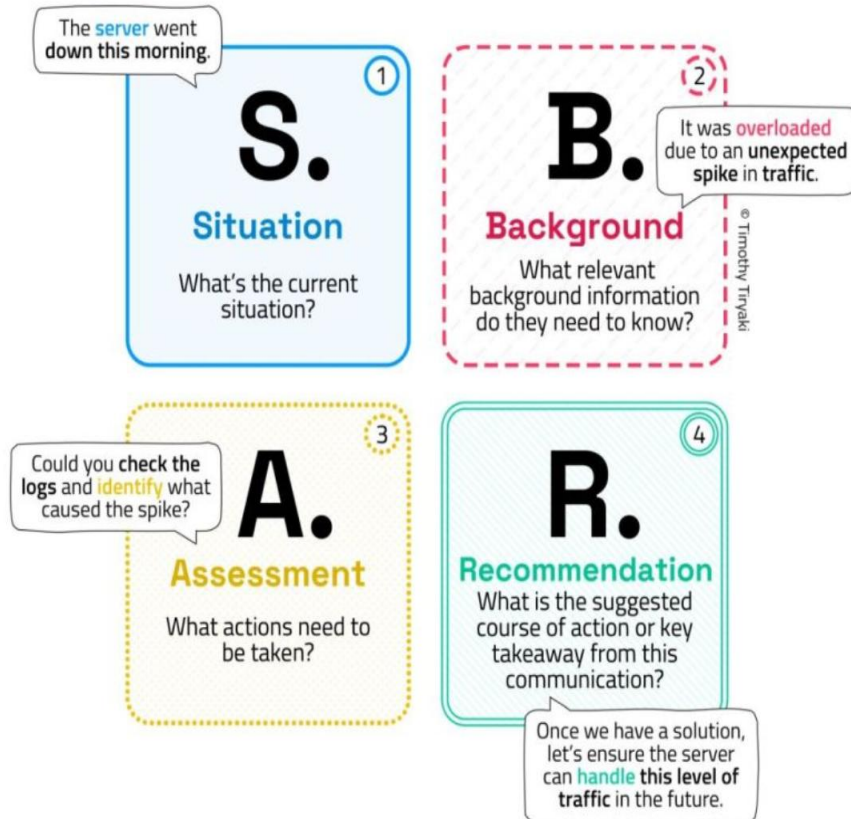
**leaders** can harness this by keeping focus on **collective problem-solving**.

**Tip:** Re-center debates on what **unites the team**, not what **divides them**.



# The SBAR Technique

A Practical Tool for Clarity in Communication



[https://www.linkedin.com/posts/mohannad-al-sereihy\\_sbar-communication-leadership-activity-7263509294614990848-lfms/](https://www.linkedin.com/posts/mohannad-al-sereihy_sbar-communication-leadership-activity-7263509294614990848-lfms/)

## Feedback formula

- Describe behaviour
- Explain **impact**
- Suggest improvement

## Final Remarks!

### You can/understand :



- identify conflict types
- understand cultural conflict triggers
- apply structured solutions
- communicate professionally in conflict situations



## Time for - Real- Use Cases Analysis

## Case-Based Exercise (Conflict Management)

Your group is assigned [look → ]  
a case material [following slides]

Case Assignment:

Breakout Rooms - Group number:

**Case No = RoomNo. Mod 3**

0 → case 3



**Your Task (Group Work) [10-15 mins]:** Analyse the situation using a structured approach:

### 1. Identify the Conflict Type

- Task conflict (work/content)
- Relationship conflict (personal/emotional)
- Process/role conflict

### 2. Analyse the Root Cause

- Culture (communication style, expectations)
- Roles / responsibilities (GRPI)
- Leadership / hierarchy
- Misunderstanding or assumptions

### 3. Propose a Solution

- What should be done differently?
- How can communication improve?
- What role should leadership play?

**Think about:**

- Culture
- Roles / structure (i.e. GRPI)
- Leadership behaviour
- Communication style

Focus on **root causes**, not symptoms

Think practically:

**What would YOU do as the leader?**

## Case Material 1: (Groups 1, 4, 7...)



A team member (Employee A) joins a new department after being **highly** recommended.

- The manager publicly highlights A's potential and future academic role
- Another team member (Employee B) feels this is **unfair and unjustified**
- B's attitude becomes **negative** toward A
- The team **atmosphere** becomes **tense**

### Over time:

- **A** feels **uncomfortable** and **demotivated**
- The conflict **spreads informally** within the team
- When a similar situation happens with another **new employee**, B shows the same reaction



## Case Material 2: (Groups 2, 5, 8...)



A project team is discussing how to proceed with a **technical** task.

- The project leader wants to try **new methods quickly**
- A **senior** expert **strongly** rejects the idea **without** proposing alternatives
- Both insist on their position
- The discussion **escalates**, becoming louder and more emotional

**A team member observing the situation:**

- recognises that both want the same goal
- feels unsure how to intervene due to **hierarchical differences**

## Case Material 3: (Groups 3, 6, 9...)



A team **leader** is responsible for **workplace** safety.

- One employee repeatedly **ignores** a safety rule (wearing protective equipment)
- **Several** conversations have already taken place
- The employee **temporarily** complies but then **returns** to non-compliant behaviour

### This leads to:

- frustration for the leader
- safety risks
- repeated conflict without resolution

## Final Remarks!

Which case was easiest to solve?

Where did **leadership matter most**?

On Teams: to be uploaded:  
**DiagnosingConflict-Expected Insights.pdf**



**Any Questions ?**